Salsa Roja

Toasted guajillo, árbol, and morita chiles are soaked, then blended with air-fried tomatoes, onion, and garlic. The puree is strained and fried in a little oil until glossy, then finished with salt and a little sugar. Makes about 2 cups.

Ingredients

Guajillo chiles 4
Árbol chiles 8
Morita chile 1
Roma tomatoes . . . . . 12 oz.
White onion . . . . . 1/4 small
Garlic cloves 3

Apple cider vinegar . . . . . 2 tsp.
Ground cumin . . . . . 1/8 tsp.
Neutral oil . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Kosher salt . . . . . 1 tsp.
Sugar . . . . . 1/2 tsp.

Directions

Preheat the air fryer to *400°F* — Stem and seed the **guajillo chiles** and the **morita chile**; stem the **árbol chiles** and leave the seeds in — Halve the **tomatoes**; cut the **onion** into wedges — Measure the **vinegar**, **cumin**, **oil**, **salt**, and **sugar**

1. Toast the **guajillo chiles** in a dry skillet over medium heat. Press them flat for about *20 seconds* per side, until fragrant and lighter inside. Keep them red-brown. Discard any that smell sharp or acrid, and toast replacements.

2. In the same skillet, stir the **árbol chiles** and the **morita chile** over medium heat until they darken in spots and smell toasty, about *1 minute*. The **morita** darkens faster. Lift it out as soon as it spots. Discard any chile that smells sharp or acrid, and toast a replacement.

3. Cover the toasted chiles with hot water. Hold them under a small plate. Soak *15–20 minutes*, until soft and pliable.

4. While the chiles soak, air-fry the **tomatoes** and **onion** at *400°F*. Place the tomato halves cut side up and the onion wedges in one layer. Cook *4–8 minutes*, until the skins begin to blister. Leave about *8 minutes* of cooking still to come.

5. Add the unpeeled **garlic cloves**. Cook about *8 minutes* more, *12–16 minutes* in all. The tomato skins should blister and blacken in patches, and the flesh should collapse when pressed. The onion edges should be black, with a soft, sweet center. A garlic clove should squeeze soft from the skin, and the inside should be golden. Continue in *2 minute* increments until the tomatoes collapse and the garlic squeezes soft. Discard a clove that is black inside.

6. Pour any juice from the air-fryer drawer into the blender.

7. Peel the **garlic**.

8. Lift the chiles out of the soaking water and keep the water.

9. Blend the chiles, **tomatoes**, **onion**, **garlic**, 2 tsp. **apple cider vinegar**, 1/8 tsp. **ground cumin**, the drawer juice, and 1/2 cup soaking water until completely smooth, about *1–2 minutes*. Add another splash of soaking water when the puree stops moving.

10. Strain the puree through a fine-mesh strainer. Press hard, until only dry skins remain. Discard the solids.

11. Heat 1 Tbsp. **neutral oil** in a small saucepan over medium heat until it shimmers.

12. Pour in the puree and stand back. It will sputter. Simmer over medium heat, stirring often, for *8–12 minutes*, until the sauce darkens a shade, the raw chile smell is gone, and it coats a spoon but still pours. Set the lid on at an angle between stirs. Stir in a spoonful of soaking water when the sauce thickens past a loose pour.

13. Take the pan off the heat. Stir in 1 tsp. **kosher salt** and 1/2 tsp. **sugar**. Taste. The sauce should be spicy, lightly smoky, and a little sweet. Add a pinch more **salt** or **sugar** as needed.

14. Cool until warm or at room temperature. The sauce thickens as it cools. Loosen with a splash of soaking water when it sets past a loose pour. Serve warm or at room temperature. Makes about 2 cups.

Equipment Required

- Medium skillet
- Small plate
- Air fryer
- Blender
- Fine-mesh strainer
- Small saucepan with a lid
- Wooden spoon or silicone spatula
- Measuring spoons and a liquid measuring cup
- Jar with a lid

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Makes about 2 cups, enough for a week of tacos.

Mise en Place

- Preheat the air fryer to *400°F* while you stem the chiles and cut the vegetables.
- Stem and seed the **guajillo chiles** and the **morita chile**. Stem the **árbol chiles** and leave the seeds in.
- Halve the **tomatoes**. Cut the **onion** into wedges. Leave the **garlic** in its skin.
- Measure the **vinegar**, **cumin**, **oil**, **salt**, and **sugar**.
- Toast and start the soak before the vegetables go into the air fryer. The soak covers the roast.

Ingredient Tips

- Choose **guajillo chiles** that bend rather than snap. Seed them. The seeds taste bitter.
- Heat sits in the **árbol** seeds. Shake out half the seeds for a milder sauce, or add 2 or 3 more chiles for a hotter one.
- Use one dried **morita**, the small sweet smoked chipotle. A chipotle meco is harsher smoke.
- Ripe red **Roma tomatoes** supply the sweetness. Pale tomatoes stay sharp.
- **Neutral oil** means safflower, canola, or grapeseed.

Preparation Tips

- Toast only until the chiles smell fragrant. Black, acrid chiles will make the whole batch bitter.
- Save the juice in the air-fryer drawer. It is sweet, and the sauce needs it.
- Press the puree hard through the strainer. Skins left in the sauce taste gritty.
- The puree spatters when it hits the hot oil. Stir, and set the lid on at an angle between stirs.
- Salt and sugar go in after the simmer so the reduction does not make them too strong.

Make Ahead & Storage

- Cool, then refrigerate in a jar up to *2 weeks*.
- Oil rises as it sits. Stir before serving.
- The sauce is best warm or at room temperature. Straight from the fridge, the chile taste is muted.
- It thickens when cold. Loosen with a spoonful of water.

Serving Suggestions

- Spoon it on tacos, fried eggs, beans, and grilled meat.
- A small spoonful is enough. The heat builds.